PROMISE & PRACTICE · AN ILLINOIS STORY

The Black Hawk War

1832 — the last armed struggle for the land of Illinois

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

1832 — the last armed struggle for the land of Illinois

In the summer of 1832, the land that would become northern Illinois became the site of its last armed struggle — a fifteen-week conflict between the United States and a people simply trying to go home.

This is the story of the Black Hawk War: how it happened here, on Illinois ground, and why it still matters to the state we live in today.

The Sauk and the Meskwaki

LONG BEFORE THE WAR

Long before there was a war, this was a homeland. It belonged to the Sauk — who called themselves Asakiwaki, "the people of the yellow earth" — and to their allies the Meskwaki, "the people of the red earth."

Two sovereign nations, not an empty wilderness. Their great town, Saukenuk, stood where the Rock River meets the Mississippi, at what is now Rock Island.

Thousands of people lived there, in bark lodges surrounded by cornfields that ran for miles. Every spring, the people returned from the winter hunt to plant.

As Black Hawk himself remembered it: "Rock River was a beautiful country. I loved my towns, my cornfields, and the home of my people.

Voices of the Nation

THEIR OWN GOVERNMENT

Now, the Sauk were not of one mind. Like any people, they debated their own future. Keokuk, a civil leader, urged accommodation — moving west, he argued, was the only way to survive.

But Black Hawk, a war leader who had fought alongside the British back in 1812, refused to abandon Saukenuk. The prophet Wabokieshiek, known as White Cloud, and a leader named Neapope encouraged him with promises of British and allied support.

Those promises would prove empty. But the choice to resist was the nation's own to make.

The Treaty No One Agreed To

THE ROOT OF THE CONFLICT

At the root of the entire conflict lay a single disputed piece of paper. In 1804, a few Sauk men signed away some fifty million acres of land east of the Mississippi to William Henry Harrison — for about a thousand dollars a year.

But those signers had no authority to sell the nation's land, and the vast majority of Sauk never agreed to it. Black Hawk called it a fraud.

The United States called it law. As Black Hawk later put it: "I touched the goose quill to the treaty — not knowing that by that act I consented to give away my village."

That single disputed page set everything else in motion.

The British Band Crosses Back

APRIL 1832

In April of 1832, Black Hawk led his people back home into Illinois. Understand what this was: not a war party, but a migration of families — men, women, and children.

He was counting on support from the British and from allied tribes. Almost none of it came. Of roughly eleven hundred people in the band, about five hundred were warriors — and the number of allies who actually arrived to help them was zero.

Behind them, the United States Army was already gathering.

A War Fought Across Illinois

THE CAMPAIGN · 1832

The first act of this war played out entirely on Illinois ground. From Saukenuk, the band moved up the Rock River and then north, out of the state.

Trace the route on the map, and you can see the shape of it — a people moving home, and an army moving to intercept them, across the rivers and prairies of northern Illinois.

Forts of the War

THE WHOLE THEATER

In Illinois — Fort Armstrong (Rock Island, at Saukenuk; Army HQ) · Fort Dixon (Dixon’s Ferry, where Lincoln, Davis & Taylor mustered) · Apple River Fort (Elizabeth; attacked June 24, 1832) · Fort Dearborn (Chicago).

The northern posts — Fort Crawford (Prairie du Chien) · Fort Winnebago (Portage) · Fort Koshkonong / “Fort Atkinson” (Gen. Atkinson’s 1832 stockade) · Fort Snelling (up the Mississippi).

Downriver — Jefferson Barracks (St. Louis), where Black Hawk was later imprisoned.

This was a war of forts, spread across a wide theater. In Illinois stood Fort Armstrong, at Rock Island — built on the site of Saukenuk itself — which served as Army headquarters.

There was Fort Dixon, where Lincoln, Davis, and Taylor all mustered in. There was the Apple River Fort, and Fort Dearborn, at Chicago.

To the north lay a chain of posts: Fort Crawford, Fort Winnebago, Fort Koshkonong, and Fort Snelling. And far downriver stood Jefferson Barracks, at St.

Louis, where Black Hawk would eventually be imprisoned.

A Map From the War Itself

DRAWN IN THE FIELD · 1832

This is a map drawn during the war, by someone who was actually there — titled "Indian Campaign of 1832, Map of the Country."

Every creek, every trail, every settlement was inked by hand in the field. It traces the very same ground the army marched across northern Illinois and up into Wisconsin.

It's history recorded in the moment, not remembered long after.

A Young Captain Lincoln

THE ILLINOIS MILITIA

When the war began, Governor John Reynolds called out the militia, and thousands of Illinois volunteers rode out alongside the U.S. Army.

One of them was a twenty-three-year-old store clerk from the village of New Salem, elected captain of his company — a young man named Abraham Lincoln.

Lincoln saw no battle in this war. But he helped bury the dead, and he never forgot what he saw.

Native Peoples on Every Side

NOT ONE SIDE, BUT MANY

And here is something crucial to understand: this was never simply "Indians versus the United States." The Potawatomi leader Shabbona rode through the night to warn white settlers of the coming danger, saving many lives.

The Ho-Chunk were divided — some sheltered Black Hawk, while others guided the army after him. The Dakota and the Menominee fought alongside the United States.

The U.S. deliberately turned old rivalries between nations into weapons of war.

The Truce That Became a War

MAY 14, 1832

By mid-May, Black Hawk realized that no help was coming. So he sent riders forward under a white flag, to surrender. But panicked Illinois militia opened fire on the truce party.

Black Hawk's warriors struck back, and routed a force far larger than their own — an embarrassment the newspapers mocked as "Stillman's Run."

And so, in an instant, a surrender had become a war. As one U.S. officer described the chaos: "There was no respect for a flag of truce, and his men were falling upon all sides from an enemy in his very midst."

Apple River Fort

JUNE 24, 1832

As the war spread into the lead-mining country, Black Hawk's warriors attacked a settler stockade called Apple River Fort, near Elizabeth, Illinois.

With the men pinned down under fire, a woman named Elizabeth Armstrong rallied the other women to mold bullets and load rifles.

The little fort held. It remains one of the sharpest, most vivid moments of the war on Illinois soil.

The Long Retreat

SUMMER 1832

By summer, the hope was gone, and it became a desperate flight. Black Hawk's people fled north, out of Illinois and into what is now Wisconsin — soldiers close behind them, and hunger steadily thinning their ranks.

On July twenty-first, at a place called Wisconsin Heights, Black Hawk fought a skilled rearguard action to get his people safely across a river.

It was a remarkable feat of leadership. But it only delayed the end.

The Bad Axe Massacre

AUGUST 1–2, 1832

The end came at the mouth of the Bad Axe River, on the first and second of August. The starving band tried, once again, to surrender and cross the Mississippi to safety.

Instead, the steamboat Warrior and the pursuing troops opened fire on them — on warriors, women, and children alike. Dakota allies of the U.S.

killed many of those who reached the far shore. Of the roughly eleven hundred people who had crossed into Illinois back in April, only about one hundred and fifty survived.

This was not a battle. It was a massacre.

IN HIS OWN WORDS

Black Hawk was captured, and paraded through the cities of the East. He met President Andrew Jackson, and then he dictated the story of his life.

Someone at his surrender said of him: "He has done nothing for which an Indian ought to be ashamed. He has fought for his countrymen — the women and children — against white men who came to cheat them and take their lands."

His autobiography, the Life of Black Hawk, published in 1833, was the first Native American autobiography ever published in the United States — his nation's side of the story, told in his own voice.

What Was Taken — and What Survived

AFTER THE WAR

The war became a pretext for taking even more. Just weeks after Bad Axe, the United States forced the Sauk and Meskwaki to give up some six million acres of eastern Iowa — a seizure cynically named the "Black Hawk Purchase."

Removal followed. Black Hawk himself died in 1838, and even his grave was later robbed. But the nations did not vanish. Their descendants endure today — as the Sac and Fox Nation of Oklahoma, the Sac and Fox Nation of Missouri, and the Meskwaki Nation of Iowa, who bought their land back and hold it still.

They are a living people — not a closed chapter.

Why Illinois Mattered

ILLINOIS' PLACE IN THE STORY

It happened here — across northern Illinois, from Saukenuk up the Rock River.

It opened the land — settlers flooded in; Chicago soon exploded into a city.

It gathered a cast — a future U.S. president (Lincoln), a future Confederate president (Davis), and a future president-general (Taylor).

So why does this Illinois story matter so much? Three reasons. First: it happened here — across northern Illinois, from Saukenuk up the Rock River.

Second: it opened the land — settlers flooded in behind the war, and Chicago soon exploded from a tiny settlement into a great city.

And third: it gathered an astonishing cast of people — including a future president of the United States, a future president of the Confederacy, and a future president-general.

An Astonishing Cast

THE MEN THE WAR GATHERED

Look at who passed through this single Illinois campaign. Lieutenant Jefferson Davis, the future president of the Confederacy. Colonel Zachary Taylor, a future president of the United States.

General Winfield Scott, the army's commander and a future presidential nominee. And Lieutenant Robert Anderson, who, thirty years later, would command Fort Sumter as the Civil War began.

A single generation gathered here — one that would go on to shape the nation, and then to tear it apart.

Lt. Jefferson Davis
future president of the Confederacy

Whose Story Is This?

THINK LIKE A HISTORIAN

Fifteen weeks. In that short time, a people who simply tried to go home lost almost everything — and the Illinois that we live in today was cleared for settlement.

So think like a historian. Was the Black Hawk War truly a "war" — or was it the removal of a people trying to return to their own land?

And whose voices should Illinois listen to, when it remembers what happened in 1832?

Credits

SOURCES & CREDITS

Portraits & battlefield views — George Catlin (Smithsonian); McKenney & Hall; Frank E. Stevens, The Black Hawk War, 1903 (Project Gutenberg).

Maps — original schematics (ShadowDog Digital Studios); period “Line of March” map — Stevens, 1903.

Names given with Sauk and Meskwaki endonyms where known; the Sauk & Fox and Meskwaki Nations remain sovereign today.

Narrative & design — ShadowDog Digital Studios · Promise & Practice.

The Reading Activity

YOUR TURN

You've heard the story. Now it's your turn to work the text yourself. In the reading activity ahead, you'll read the account in chunks and build your own understanding of the Black Hawk War, piece by piece.